Where Novels Are Set

Mapping the real places of fiction in Wikidata:
7,300 novels, 13,218 literary works and the distance from their authors' birthplaces

Tristan Hotham

Independent researcher
ORCID: 0000-0003-4931-9349
DOI: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23872997

2026

Abstract

I map the narrative locations recorded in Wikidata for every literary work whose setting has coordinates: 13,218 works, of which 7,300 are novels, set in 4,057 distinct real places. Three city areas dominate the novels: London (549 novels), New York (510) and Paris (422), which together appear in 19.9% of them. Their shares have changed over two centuries: Paris is the setting of 44% of mapped novels first published from 1830 to 1849, London leads from 1910 to 1949, New York from 1950 to 1989, and London again since 1990. For 6,654 novels with a known author birthplace and setting country, 68.8% are set entirely within the present-day country of the author's birth; the median distance from birthplace to setting is 343 km and 24.8% of settings lie within 50 km of it. Europe, with 9.7% of the world's population, has 53.5% of the novels; Asia, with 59.5%, has 9.1%. Coverage is strongly shaped by contributors: Denmark, with 0.08% of the world's people, holds 11.7% of all distinct setting places, more than any other country, and Serbia 3.4%. The results describe what Wikidata records rather than world literature, and I quantify that difference where I can.

Keywords: literary geography; novels; narrative location; Wikidata; distant reading; digital humanities; open data; mapping

1 Introduction

Literary geography asks where stories happen and why (Moretti, 1998). Most work in the field studies a single author, city or national literature, because assembling the settings of many books by hand is slow. Wikidata, the collaboratively edited knowledge base behind Wikipedia, now records a narrative location (property P840) for thousands of works, each linked to a place item that usually has coordinates. That makes it possible to draw a world map of fictional settings at the scale of thousands of books, and to ask simple comparative questions. Which cities does fiction favour? How has that changed over time? How far do authors travel from where they were born? Which parts of the world are written about least?

The same data also raise a methodological question. Wikidata is assembled by volunteers, some working through organised projects that add whole national literatures at once. A map of its narrative locations is therefore partly a map of where that effort has gone. I treat this as a finding in its own right and quantify it (Section 4.6).

2 Data

A single query, run with the QLever SPARQL engine (Bast and Buchhold, 2017) against Wikidata (Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014) in 2026, returned every item that is an instance of a subclass of

literary work (Q7725634) and has a narrative location whose item has coordinates (P625), with the item's English label, publication date (P577), authors (P50), the coordinates of each author's place of birth (P19), sitelinks and language (P407): 19,443 rows for 13,241 works. Further queries supplied each work's classes (P31), genres (P136), country of origin (P495), languages, form of creative work (P7937), sitelinks and English Wikipedia article, and each place's classes and country (P17). 33 work and place pairs have coordinates on the Moon or Mars; these 23 works set only off Earth are counted but not mapped, leaving 13,218 works with 16,926 settings on Earth in 4,057 places. Country outlines, populations and populated places are from Natural Earth (Natural Earth, 2026).

3 Methods

3.1 Novels

A work is a novel if its form of creative work is novel or novella, or if it is an instance of a class whose English label contains "novel" (for example graphic novel or unfinished novel). This gives 7,256 works by form and 56 more by class. I make two exceptions: Wikidata files each of the 67 tales of the Decameron as a "novella in the Decameron", and gives the Odyssey's form as novel. Neither is a novel in the usual sense, and both are kept among the literary works only. The result is 7,300 novels. The other 5,918 literary works are mainly plays, short stories, operas and other narratives.

3.2 Places

Each place is assigned a level from its Wikidata classes: city or town (1,720 places), site or part of a city such as a street, building or neighbourhood (1,098), wider area such as a state, county, island or region (839), country, former state or civilisation (342), and continent, ocean or world region (58). Places in classes containing "fictional" or "phantom" (15, such as Arkham or 221B Baker Street) are flagged and excluded from claims about real places. A place's country is the present-day Natural Earth country containing its point (or the nearest within 0.3 degrees); for country-level items the matching Natural Earth country. City areas group every city or site within 25 km of a Natural Earth populated place of at least 250,000 people with that place. "Set in" a city, country or continent means that at least one of the work's settings is there.

3.3 Home and abroad

An author's home country is the present-day country of their birthplace coordinates. A novel is set at home if all its settings with a country lie in the home country of one of its authors, and abroad otherwise. Distances are great-circle distances from each point setting (city, site or area) to the nearest of the work's authors' birthplaces. Birthplace is not nationality: writers born in colonies, empires or before border changes are assigned to today's country of their birthplace.

3.4 Genres, periods and fame

Genres are grouped by regular expressions on Wikidata's genre labels into crime and mystery, science fiction, fantasy, historical fiction, horror and gothic, and children's and young adult fiction.

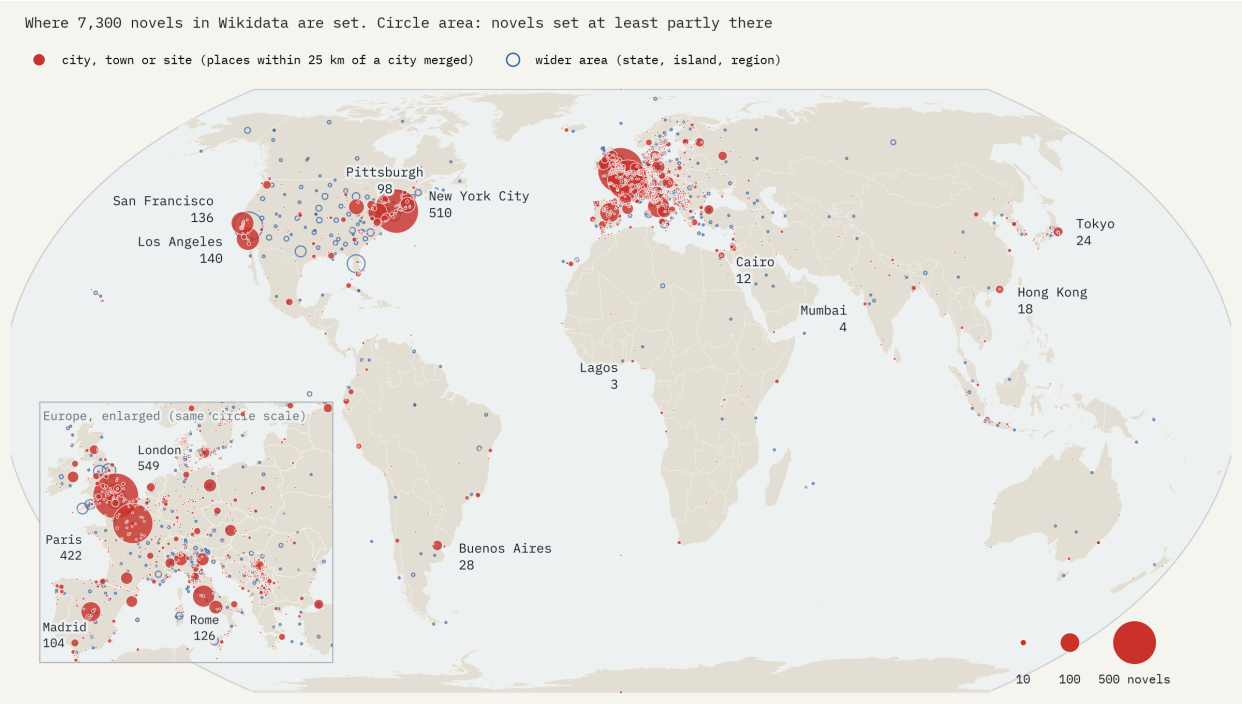


Figure 1: Novels' settings in Wikidata. Filled circles: city areas, towns and sites; rings: wider areas. Circle area is proportional to the number of novels. Inset: Europe at the same circle scale.

The publication year is the earliest recorded publication date. The number of Wikipedia language editions with an article on a work (sitelinks) is used as a rough measure of fame.

4 Results

4.1 Where novels are set

Figure 1 maps the novels' settings. 5,306 novels (72.7%) have at least one city, site or area; 1,994 name only a country or larger area. Table 1 lists the leading city areas. London (549), New York (510) and Paris (422) are far ahead of Los Angeles (140), San Francisco (136), Rome (126) and Madrid (104). Counting all literary works, Paris leads (877). Prolific authors shape the ranking: Pérez Galdós accounts for 37 of Madrid's novels, Rex Stout for 43 of New York's and Simenon for 38 of Paris's. Pittsburgh ranks eighth (98), ahead of Chicago (65); Mumbai has 4 and Lagos 3. By country, the United States has 2,151 novels and the United Kingdom 1,216; together they appear in 45.8% of all novels.

4.2 London, Paris and New York over time

Figure 2 shows each city's share of novels with a mapped place by twenty-year period of first publication. Paris is the setting of 44.0% of novels published from 1830 to 1849 (n = 75), when London has 10.7% and New York 2.7%. London and Paris are level from 1890 to 1909, London leads from 1910 to 1949, New York from 1950 to 1989 (15.4% from 1950 to 1969), and London again since 1990 (11.2% from 1990 to 2009). Paris falls to 5.0% from 1990 to 2009. All three shares decline in the most recent period as the settings of recent novels spread over many more places.

Table 1: The twenty city areas with the most novels set at least partly in them, and all literary works.

	City area	Country	Novels	All works
1	London	United Kingdom	549	786
2	New York City	United States	510	813
3	Paris	France	422	877
4	Los Angeles	United States	140	179
5	San Francisco	United States	136	173
6	Rome	Italy	126	212
7	Madrid	Spain	104	240
8	Pittsburgh	United States	98	103
9	Chicago	United States	65	85
10	Boston	United States	60	80
11	Milan	Italy	50	76
12	Naples	Italy	49	94
13	Berlin	Germany	45	81
14	Venice	Italy	44	81
15	Toulouse	France	39	42
16	Vienna	Austria	37	64
17	Barcelona	Spain	35	41
18	Dublin	Ireland	34	50
19	Copenhagen	Denmark	33	108
20	Turin	Italy	28	29

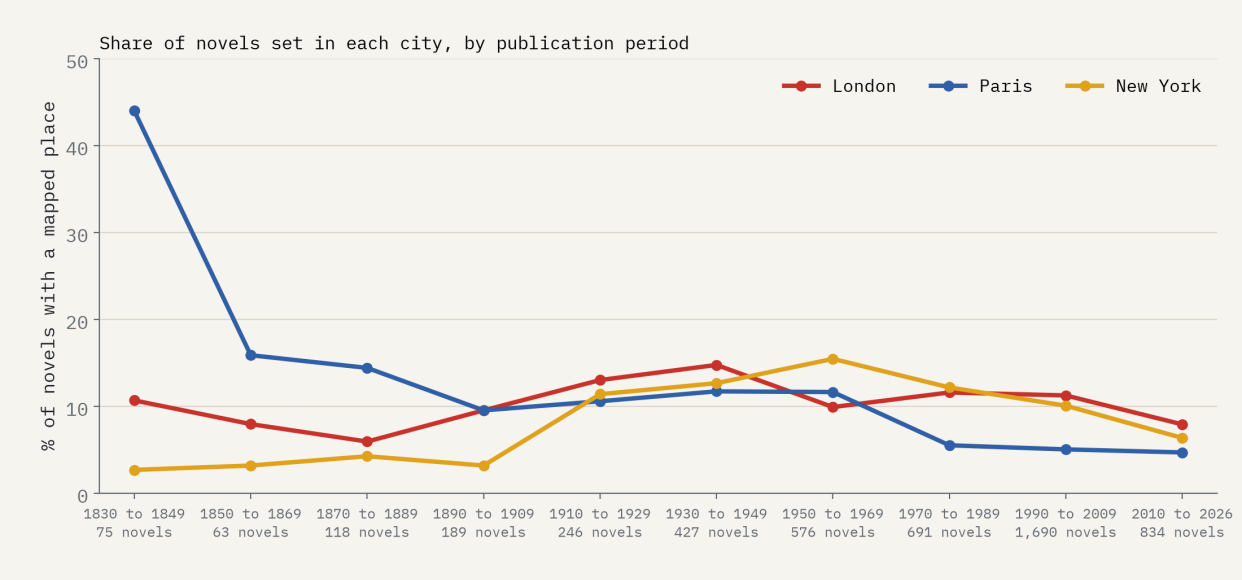


Figure 2: Share of novels with a mapped place set at least partly in London, Paris and New York, by period of first publication.

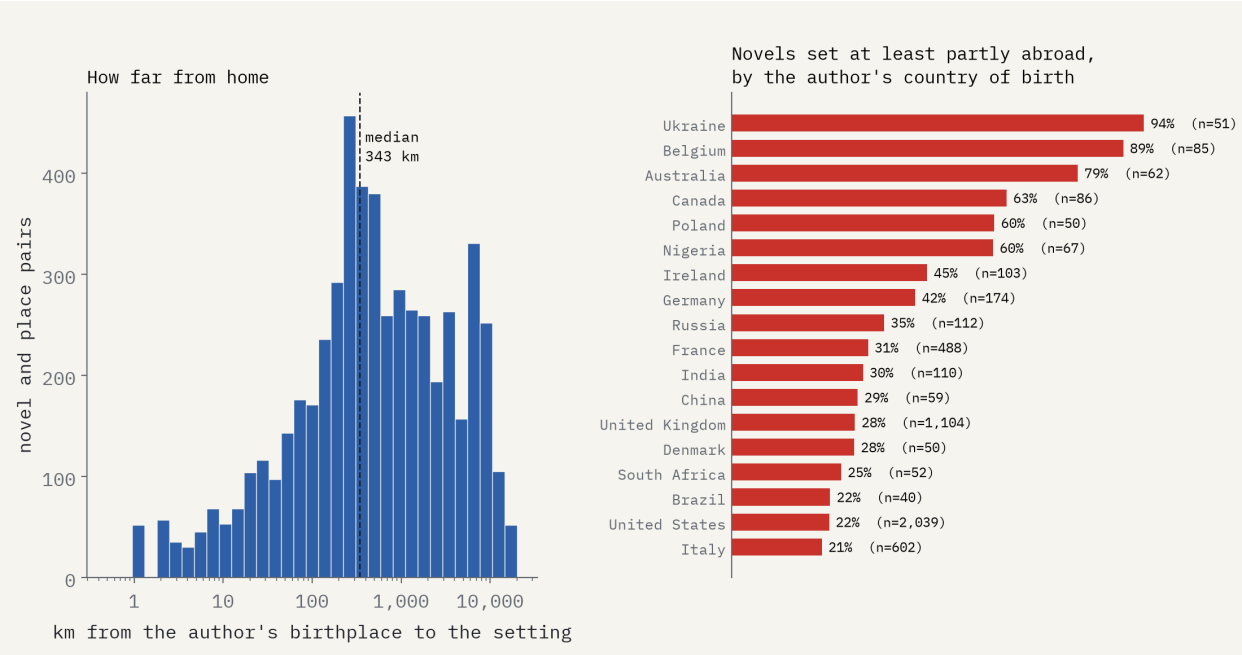


Figure 3: Left: distance from the author's birthplace to each point setting of a novel (log scale). Right: share of novels set at least partly abroad, by present-day country of the author's birthplace (at least 40 novels).

4.3 Home and abroad

Of 6,654 novels with a home country and a setting country, 2,079 (31.2%) are set at least partly abroad and 1,847 (27.8%) entirely abroad. Across 6,147 novel and point-setting pairs, the median distance from the author's birthplace is 343 km (mean 1,713 km); 24.8% lie within 50 km, 57.8% within 500 km and 13.3% beyond 5,000 km (Figure 3). The share abroad ranges by period from 26% for novels published from 1800 to 1849 to 38% from 1900 to 1949 and 32% since 2000. Table 2 gives the share by birth country. The highest shares reflect the gap between birthplace and nationality: writers born in present-day Ukraine (94%), Belgium (89%, chiefly Simenon) and Australia (79%). American-born writers set 22.3% of their novels abroad and British-born writers 28.2%. The longest single journey is Ngaio Marsh's, from Christchurch to Devon in Death at the Bar (19,174 km); among 398 authors with at least three mapped novels, Marsh (median 18,976 km) and P. L. Travers (16,327 km) travel furthest.

4.4 Genres

Figure 4 gives the leading cities for each genre group. Crime and mystery (869 novels) is led by Paris (95), London (82) and New York (59); relative to all novels it is over-represented in Miami, Oslo, Edinburgh and Venice. Science fiction with a real setting (413) goes mostly to New York and London, and is 3.5 times as likely as the average novel to be set in San Francisco; 49.4% of it is set at least partly in the United States. Fantasy (361) is led by London (47), and historical fiction (586) by Paris, London and New York, with Italy (68 novels) prominent among countries. 25 works are set at least partly on the Moon and 3 on Mars.

4.5 Continents and population

Figure 5 and Table 3 compare the share of novels set in each continent with its share of world population. Europe has 51.4 novels per 10 million people, North America 39.2, South America

Table 2: Novels by the present-day country of the author's birthplace (at least 40): share set at least partly abroad, median distance from birthplace to point settings, and the main foreign settings.

Born in	Novels	Abroad	Median km	Main foreign settings
Ukraine	51	94.1%	1,697	Russia 11, United States 9, Italy 8
Belgium	85	89.4%	305	France 64, United Kingdom 3, China 2
Australia	62	79.0%	16,327	United Kingdom 24, Germany 4, Ireland 3
Canada	86	62.8%	797	United States 26, United Kingdom 10, China 5
Poland	50	60.0%	168	Germany 7, France 4, United States 4
Nigeria	67	59.7%	5,020	Italy 24, United Kingdom 6, United States 3
Ireland	103	44.7%	456	United Kingdom 25, United States 9, France 5
Germany	174	42.0%	307	France 12, United States 11, Italy 10
Russia	112	34.8%	1,066	United States 9, Germany 8, France 5
France	488	31.1%	208	Egypt 30, Italy 21, United States 21
India	110	30.0%	5,976	United Kingdom 14, United States 7, France 3
China	59	28.8%	8,271	United Kingdom 6, Canada 3, France 3
United Kingdom	1,104	28.2%	155	United States 91, France 39, Ireland 32
Denmark	50	28.0%	101	Germany 4, Italy 3, France 2
South Africa	52	25.0%	8,674	United Kingdom 5, United States 2, Spain 2
Brazil	40	22.5%	362	France 3, United States 2, Egypt 1
United States	2,039	22.3%	1,020	United Kingdom 143, France 57, Italy 48
Italy	602	20.6%	64	France 16, United States 10, Germany 9
Japan	66	16.7%	362	United States 4, China 2, United Kingdom 1
Spain	262	16.4%	395	France 15, Italy 7, United States 5
Sweden	91	13.2%	278	United States 3, Germany 3, South Africa 1

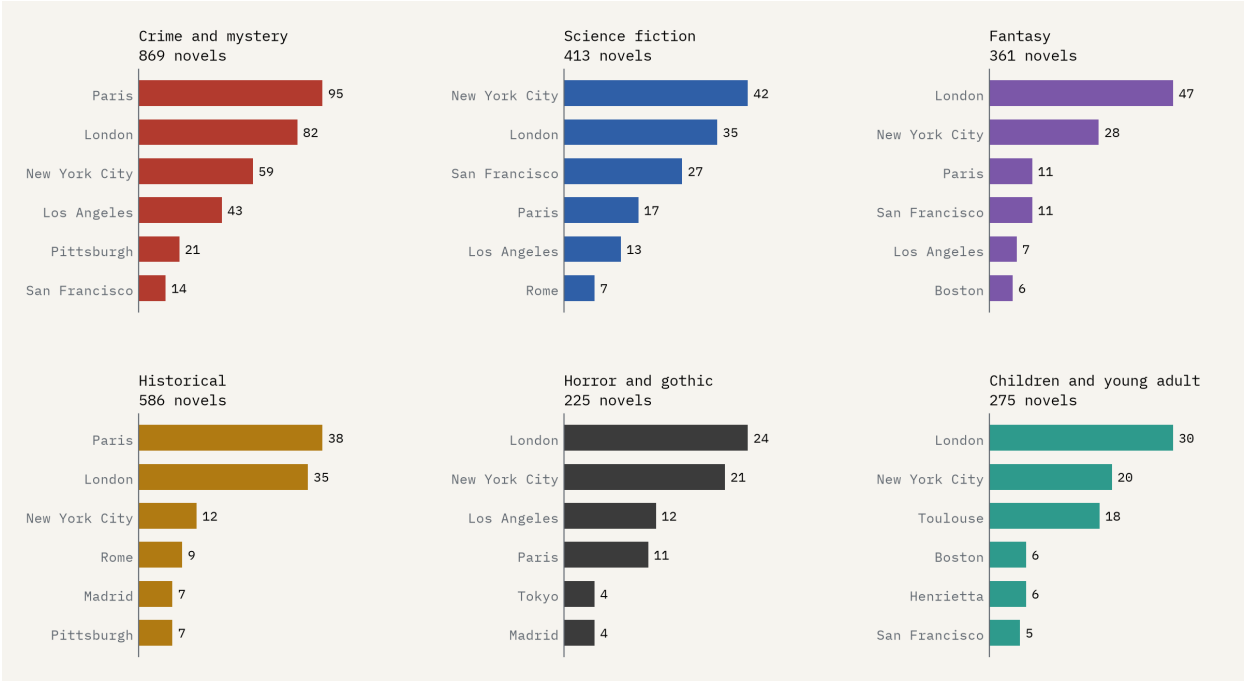


Figure 4: Leading city areas for each genre group. A novel may belong to more than one group.

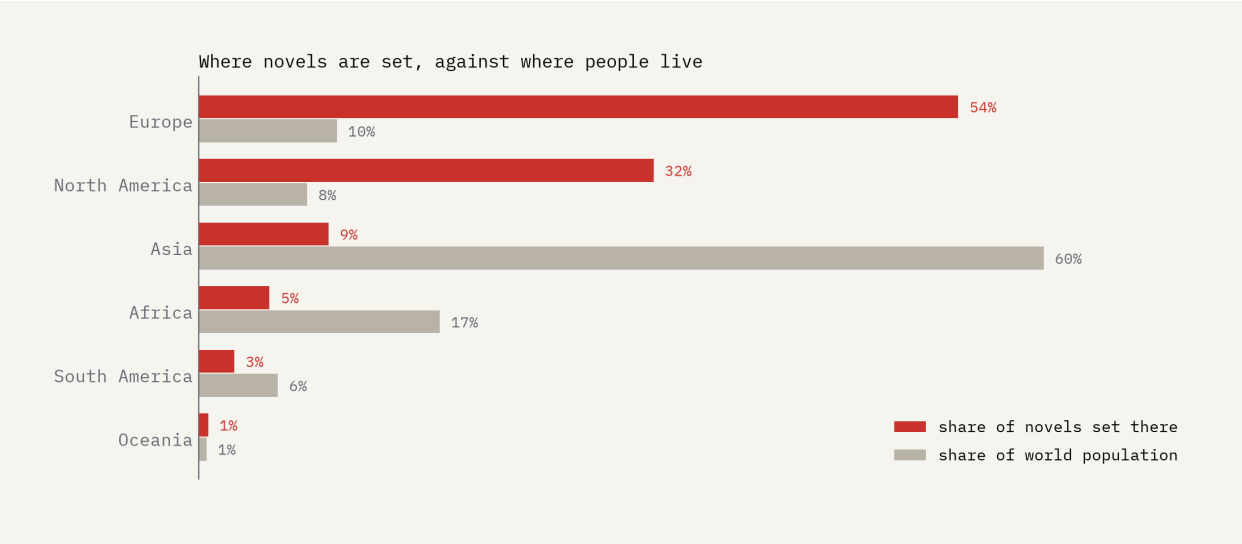


Figure 5: Share of novels with a setting in each continent (a novel may count for several) against share of world population.

Table 3: Novels and literary works set at least partly in each continent, share of world population, and novels per 10 million people (not given for Antarctica).

Continent	Novels	Share	Works	Population	Per 10m
Europe	3,836	53.5%	7,236	9.7%	51.4
North America	2,297	32.0%	3,623	7.6%	39.2
Asia	655	9.1%	1,440	59.5%	1.4
Africa	358	5.0%	621	17.0%	2.7
South America	180	2.5%	347	5.6%	4.2
Oceania	48	0.7%	107	0.6%	11.3
Antarctica	7	0.1%	17	0.0%	n/a

4.2, Africa 2.7 and Asia 1.4. Among countries of 50 million people or more the least mapped are Bangladesh (2 novels), the Philippines (3), the Democratic Republic of the Congo (4), Myanmar (3) and Pakistan (13). 7 countries of more than 10 million people have no mapped novel.

4.6 Coverage and contributors

Counting distinct places rather than novels exposes the effect of individual cataloguing efforts (Figure 6). Denmark has 476 distinct setting places (11.7% of all), more than the United States (410), and 154 times its share of world population; China and India together have 110. Works in Danish average 3.01 settings each against 1.13 for English; one Danish novel, Koordinater, lists 53 places, and 94.8% of Denmark's places come from works in Danish. 132 of the 189 streets and squares in the data are in Denmark. Serbia has 137 places (37 times its population share), 89.0% from works in Serbian, which average 5.46 settings and were 95.5% published before 1930. The novel counts used elsewhere are much less affected: Denmark has 57 mapped novels and Serbia 54. Smaller clusters, such as Pittsburgh's 98 novels and Toulouse's 39, show the same effect at city scale.

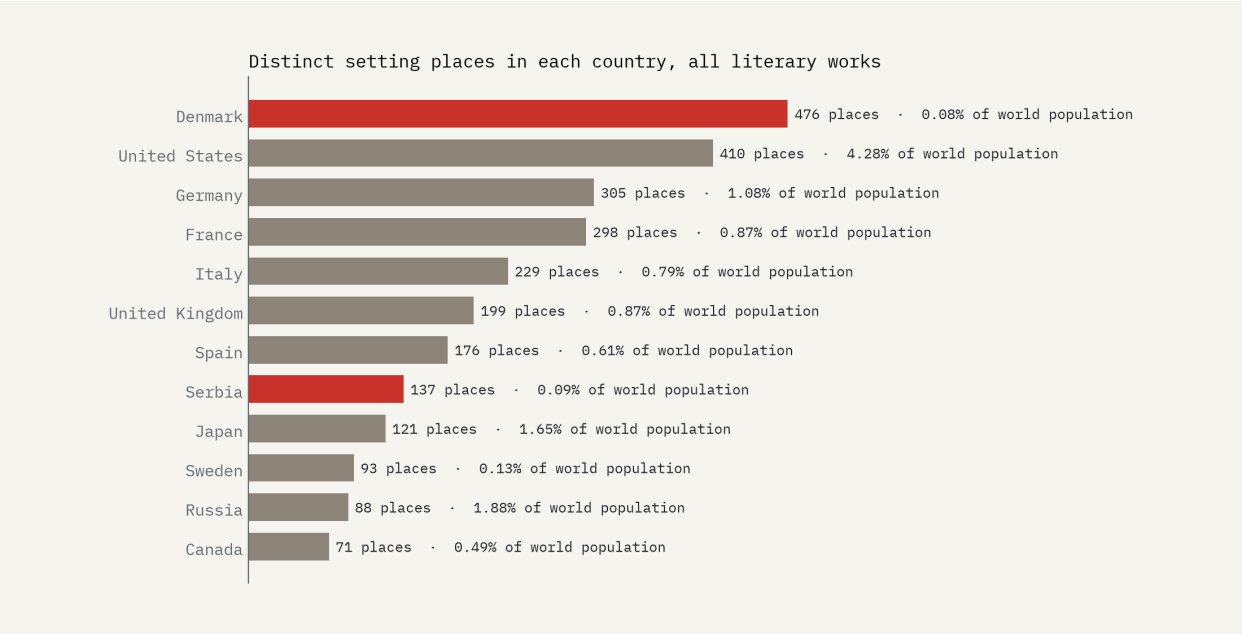


Figure 6: Distinct setting places by country, all literary works, with each country's share of world population.

4.7 Fame and extremes

The best-known novel in the data by sitelinks is Don Quixote (147 language editions), followed by Nineteen Eighty-Four (138) and Animal Farm (122). Table 4 lists the best-known novel set at least partly in each of the leading countries; well-travelled books win in many places (Robinson Crusoe in Venezuela, The Alchemist in Egypt). The most remote real setting, measured as distance to the nearest city of a million people, is the South Pole (5,802 km), followed by islands of French Polynesia (Marquesas Islands, 5,150 km). The northernmost setting is the North Pole. The street with the most works is Istedgade in Copenhagen (4), and the single site is Auschwitz (7).

Table 4: The best-known novel (by Wikipedia language editions) set at least partly in each of the forty countries with the most mapped novels.

Country	Novels	Best-known novel	Author	Year	Links
United States	2,151	The Catcher in the Rye	J. D. Salinger	1951	86
United Kingdom	1,216	Nineteen Eighty-Four	George Orwell	1949	138
Italy	705	The Count of Monte Cristo	Alexandre Dumas	1844	79
France	669	Les Misérables		1862	98
Spain	284	Don Quixote	Miguel de Cervantes	1605	147
Germany	200	Candide	Voltaire	1759	65
India	158	Around the World in Eighty Days	Jules Verne	1872	79
Russia	154	Crime and Punishment	Fyodor Dostoyevsky	1866	109
Ireland	129	Ulysses	James Joyce	1922	84
China	111	Dream of the Red Chamber	Cao Xueqin	1792	117
Sweden	91	The Wonderful Adventures of Nils	Selma Lagerlöf	1906	45
Japan	86	Around the World in Eighty Days	Jules Verne	1872	79
Egypt	79	The Alchemist	Paulo Coelho	1988	92
Nigeria	79	Things Fall Apart	Chinua Achebe	1958	38
Canada	73	The Call of the Wild	Jack London	1903	54
Austria	69	War and Peace	Leo Tolstoy	1869	97
Denmark	57	A Journey to the Centre of the Earth	Jules Verne	1864	64
Serbia	54	Impure Blood	Borisav Stanković	1910	7
Poland	52	The Good Soldier Švejk	Jaroslav Hašek	1921	55
Mexico	51	The Pearl	John Steinbeck	1947	31

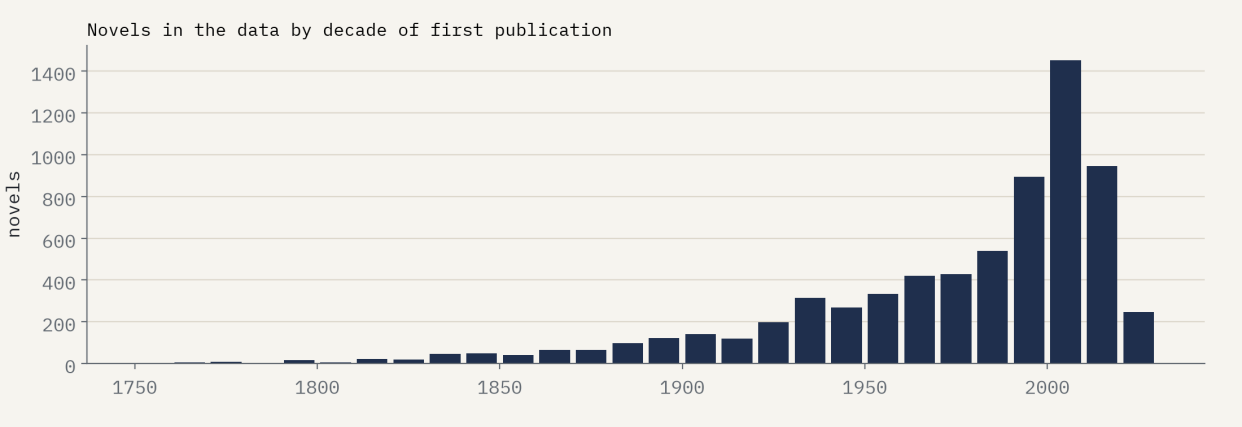


Figure 7: Novels in the data by decade of first publication.

Country	Novels	Best-known novel	Author	Year	Links
Turkey	50	Candide	Voltaire	1759	65
Brazil	48	Candide	Voltaire	1759	65
South Africa	47	Disgrace	J. M. Coetzee	1999	23
Argentina	44	Candide	Voltaire	1759	65
Greece	41	Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea	Jules Verne	1869	77
Finland	39	Colorless Tsukuru Tazaki and His Years of Pilgrimage	Haruki Murakami	2013	28
Kenya	38	Out of Africa	Karen Blixen	1937	21
Netherlands	37	The Fault in Our Stars	John Green	2012	50
Norway	37	Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea	Jules Verne	1869	77
Ecuador	36	Galápagos	Kurt Vonnegut	1985	17
Vietnam	33	The Quiet American	Graham Greene	1955	22
Australia	28	In Search of the Castaways	Jules Verne	1864	47
Indonesia	28	Max Havelaar	Multatuli	1940	33
Czech Republic	26	The Good Soldier Švejk	Jaroslav Hašek	1921	55
Israel	26	The Master and Margarita	Mikhail Bulgakov	1928	79
Switzerland	26	Angels & Demons	Dan Brown	2000	63
Belgium	22	Tintin in the Land of the Soviets	Hergé	1929	29
Iran	22	Persepolis	Marjane Satrapi		38
Portugal	21	Candide	Voltaire	1759	65
Croatia	20	Čuvaj se senjske ruke	August Šenoa	1876	2

5 Limitations

First, this is a study of Wikidata, not of literature: a work enters only if someone has recorded a narrative location with coordinates, and the records favour books with Wikipedia articles, English labels (2,301 works have none) and active national projects. Second, settings are often partial, and their precision varies from a street to a whole country; some records use a state (New York) where the city is meant. Third, levels, genres and novel status are derived from Wikidata's classes by rules that will misclassify some items. Fourth, home countries use present-day borders and birthplaces, not nationality. Fifth, publication years are the earliest recorded, and recent decades are far better covered than earlier ones (Figure 7).

6 Conclusion

The settings Wikidata records for 7,300 novels describe a fiction that is metropolitan, Euro-American and close to home. Three cities account for about a fifth of the novels, their order has shifted from Paris to London to New York and back to London, and most authors set their stories within a few hundred kilometres of where they were born. The same map shows how strongly open knowledge bases reflect the work of their contributors: a dedicated Danish effort has made Denmark the most finely mapped literary landscape on Earth, while most of Asia and Africa remains thin. Both are worth knowing, and both can change as the data grow.

Data and code availability

The interactive map is at https://maps.tristanhotham.com/novel-settings/. Data and code are at https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/novel-settings and archived with this paper at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23872997. Derived data are released under CC BY 4.0 and code under the MIT licence. Wikidata is CC0.

AI statement

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude (Anthropic), which also helped prepare the analysis code. I reviewed and checked all text and results.

References

Bast, H. and Buchhold, B. (2017) QLever: a query engine for efficient SPARQL+Text search. Proceedings of CIKM 2017, 647 to 656.

Moretti, F. (1998) Atlas of the European Novel 1800 to 1900. London: Verso.

Natural Earth (2026) Admin 0 countries and populated places, 1:50m and 1:10m. Public domain. https://www.naturalearthdata.com/

Vrandečić, D. and Krötzsch, M. (2014) Wikidata: a free collaborative knowledgebase. Communications of the ACM 57(10), 78 to 85. CC0 data at https://www.wikidata.org/